She Wasn't First

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24926905.

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Not Rated

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by not_cricketing (cricketing)

Summary

"What about this is 'fighting for Etheria'? They're destroying the world, and they're tearing people apart in the process. This is what you're fighting for?"
Catra shook her head, dread building in her stomach. No, she didn't want to tear little kids apart from their families. She had been torn apart from her family, and that had only led to heartbreak and distress. No, she was fighting to stay with Adora. She wasn't fighting for the Horde. She was fighting for her friend.
"No… No, I don't fight for them. I don't!" her voice was desperate. She needed these people to understand. She wasn't hurting families in the way she had been hurt. She needed them to know that if it weren't for Adora, she wouldn't have stayed. She would have left long ago. How was she supposed to explain that to these rebels? How was she supposed to say "Yeah, I keep fighting for an evil regime because I'm too scared of being alone,".

AKA An AU where Catra is She-ra, not Adora.

Notes

First, this is 27 pages long, single spaced in word. I'm sorry, but I am NOT about to revise that lmao. You get what you get, I supposed.
Second, there is a VERY high chance this is going to get abandoned. I'm not saying that because I want compliments, I'm saying that because you should not get invested if you hate when stories get abandoned. This first chapter alone took almost three weeks to write, between everything else going on in my life.

Lastly, this is a character study purely for my own writing practice. I'm publishing it because I like compliments. The plot is probably not going to diverge too much from the original show, because that's not what I'm trying to practice. I'm just trying to work on my show-not-tell skills when it comes to environment, and my character motivation skills. This is NOT a plot-based work, and it will closely follow the show. I'm just here to play with characters and see how they would react if the situation had been reversed, without any change in character motivations. Catra is still driven by personal relationships and Adora is still driven by personal responsibilities.

Thank you so much for reading :) I really appreciate each and every one of you.

See the end of the work for more notes

There are some people in the world who hate routines. The rigidity of a daily schedule can be annoying to some, and a burden to others. Few people in the world actually enjoyed waking up before the sun and following a strict set of habits like clockwork.

Not Adora. She relished in it, thrived in it. They made her who she was. Structure, discipline, perfection. That's what she prided herself on. Her mornings always began the same way. The same clothes, the same routines, the same effort, the same results. The same boots that gave her just the right amount of mobility in the ankles without any loss of support. The same high ponytail, practical for keeping flyaways out of her face during battle. The same set of armor plating, the cool metal always acting as a balm for her early morning nerves. The same toothpaste, the same punching bag hype-up session, the same salute to the mirror.

Standing at attention next to her squad, she distinctly felt the absence of the same person who had also been missing yesterday morning.

"Pssst." She whispered, careful to keep her voice low enough that their instructor couldn't hear her.

"Anyone seen Catra?"

Her squad members all shook their heads. Lonnie, a solidly built girl with dreads pulled back tight against her scalp, rolled her eyes and scoffed. Adora ignored her attitude.

Ugh, not again, Adora thought to herself. Lonnie shushed her. Oops. Maybe she hadn't kept that thought to herself. Damn it. She needed to keep better control of her mouth.

"At attention, cadets." Their instructor paced in front of them, walking the length of the giant door to the training simulation space.

"Your simulation is about to start. Here's your scenario. You'll be passing through the treacherous Whispering Woods…"

The door's inbuilt monitors flicked on to display a haunting image. Gnarled, white trees curled out of the ground, with ugly, knotted roots spiraling in every direction. Branches stuck out of the trees at crooked angles, almost resembling spiny fingers reaching towards her. Several pairs of bright, beady eyes peered out of the inky darkness surrounding the trees. Adora suppressed a shiver before it could pass down her spine.

She'd never admit it, but the Whispering Woods scared her. There was so much darkness in the images they had seen, so many ways to lose control. It always seemed like something was waiting just around the corner to take her by surprise. She'd much rather go into the Crimson Waste alone without water than travel into the Whispering Woods fully armed with her squad. At least in the Crimson Waste, she could see the things that were trying to kill her as they came and not get jumped by some monster hiding behind a tree. Not that she couldn't take down anything that came at her. Of course not. She just… didn't like the idea of surprise attacks. Obviously. A quick glance sideways at Lonnie's face and Adora realized that she wasn't the only one scared of the Woods. At least she was better at hiding it than her squad members. Her instructor continued on, completely oblivious to Adora's internal monologue.

"…to reach the heart of rebel insurgency. Bright Moon." An image of a castle appeared on the screens, with large bat wings adorning the highest tower. Giant spires rose out of the roof of the building, vaguely resembling the bones of an animal gutted and turned out decades ago. Next to Adora, the smallest member of their squad – a petite blonde boy named Kyle – whimpered at the sight of the building. She had to admit, it was an impressive sight. Still, better than the Woods.

"Your mission is to defeat the Queen of the Princesses and liberate Bright Moon in Lord Hordak's name." An image of a giant appeared. She was easily several times the height of an average

person, with hair billowing down past her shoulder. A glowing crystal was adorned to her forehead, and a sickly smile was spread across her face. Below her, villagers cowered in fear, terrified of the evil magic she could wield.

That's what princesses did. They hurt people. They used their magic for evil, to subjugate everyone they could and take whatever they could grab with their bloody hands. That's what Adora and her squad were training to fight. Evil, magic-wielding princesses who could wipe the floor with them with just a single, well-placed bolt of magic. That's why Adora had to be the best. Any less than perfect and she – or one of her friends – would end up dead. She had been trained since she was a baby to be absolutely perfect, and she wouldn't – no, couldn't – accept anything less.

The instructor cleared his throat, an irritated sound that brought Adora to the height of attention.

"Where is Catra?" he asked, barely attempting to cover his sigh.

Adora squared her shoulders. "She will be here. I promise." She didn't have to look at him to know Kyle was giving her a concerned side eye.

The instructor mmhmm-ed and moved on. He was used to Catra not showing up. If Adora were being honest with herself, she'd say that everyone in the Horde was used to Catra not showing up. She had a reputation for not doing as told, and that included not showing up to mandatory trainings. It was incredible that she hadn't been discharged from service by this point. Adora was pretty sure it was only because she, like Adora, was a ward of one of the most powerful people in their army. That had to count for something to someone, right?

"The Whispering Woods is full of princesses. Vicious, violent instigators." Adora steeled herself, frowning in concentration, as the instructor spoke. The doors were opening soon, and if she

weren't prepared, she could get blasted by a sim-princess as soon as she walked inside.

"They will take you out if given the chance." The huge door in front of them opened, splitting into several pieces that retracted into the doorsill. "Don't give it to them. Good luck recruits."

She and her squad walked cautiously into the simulation room. She brushed a finger over the sensor on her VR goggles and they flicked on in an instant, overlaying the room's normal criss-crossed steel beam structural supports with vital information about her surroundings. Environmental data, temperature, time, and sound levels flashed before her eyes as she scanned the room.

There! Up on her right, about ten feet above her line of sight was a bot. In her sim-goggles, she saw a bright fuchsia hologram of a princess overlaying the practice bot, with claws at the ready and a vicious smile on its face. The princess looked downright evil, as if it could actually disembowel her with its pinky finger like the Horde horror stories said. Adora shook her head. Focus, concentrate. Be perfect.

The bot shot a beam of red electricity at her. "Watch out!" She shouted. As she ducked the blast, three more princess bots came into view. Kyle, of course, ran screaming. Rogelio charged over the bots, not even bothering to take them out, just jumping over them the way he did the hurdles on the conditioning track. Lonnie stayed tight to Kyle, probably expecting that he'd need some help sooner rather than later. They all needed to get through this simulation intact, it was how they passed. Losing one person could mean dooming the entire squad to death if they were in the real world, so they trained for perfection. No man down. Kyle, always proved to be a little bit of a dead weight in combat situations. Don't get her wrong, Adora knew he had other skills… they just didn't really help on the battlefield. And she couldn't think of any other skills he had anyways. Whatever.

She tossed a hand bomb onto one of the princess bots and waited for it to explode before directing her squad to follow her.

“Come on, this way!” She ran forward, dodging the beams from the bots. Behind her, a strangled cry sounded out. Kyle. He had been hit.

The beams from the simulation bots weren’t deadly, thankfully. Unfortunately, they delivered a pretty nasty shock to whomever got hit. This time was no exception. Red electric bolts arced off of Kyle’s body for a few seconds before dissipating with a quiet crackle.

Damn. One man down. They’d have to do everything perfectly to make it through the rest of this without losing everyone else.

Catra sat up on the steel supports, watching. She loved to sit and observe, to take in the entire layout of their simulations before getting involved. Eagle eye views were very helpful in establishing where her enemies and friends were. It made it easier to protect herself when she was on the ground.
Technically, she was late. Technically.

She hadn’t shown up to the briefing prior to the simulation, which made her late. She didn’t understand why everyone got so huffy about her skipping the routine stuff, like briefings. It was always the same thing. Princesses, blah blah, Liberation, blah, Bright Moon, blah blah blah. It was a snooze fest, and Catra really hated having to listen to it day after day. So, she skipped. Every day, while her instructors were busy talking about the same old simulation set up, she tried to find new and interesting ways into the simulation room. Air ducts, pipe shafts, service doors, all of it. It was way more fun than briefings. Once she entered the room, she’d climb up onto the rafters and look for where the bots were placed for the day. She had mentally catalogued about a fifty different attack strategies that the bots cycled through at random, and a quick glance at today’s set-up indicated that her squadron was going to have a little bit of a rough time getting through it. If she were a betting person, she’d bet Kyle would be the first to go down. It was like the old saying: only bet on something if you know it’s a fact. Kyle going down first? Fact.

Now, the interesting question was who was going down last? Rogelio, the largest member of their squad, often relied on avoidance tactics, preferring to just get to the end goal rather than get caught up with the smaller bots on their way in. He'd probably go down quickly, since this simulation was one of the few where the bots would chase down whichever person they encountered first, rather than the closest person to them.

Lonnie would get cocky. She always did. It was almost never the bots that took her down. No, it was always the environmental factors. Like simulated falling debris or the mock unstable ground. Adora, then, Catra decided. Adora would be the last to stay standing. Regardless of how jealous she could get of her best friend's accomplishment's, Catra had to admit that Adora was a damn good fighter. Almost perfect. She had a habit of getting distracted when surprised, but otherwise, she almost never made a mistake. Even Shadow Weaver, their shared guardian who had no trouble finding faults in anyone and everyone, could rarely find anything about Adora to complain about. Catra was proud of her, even if her own personal pride was a little dinged by the admission.

The main door to the simulation room opened, and the bots powered up, ready to start electrocuting everyone in their sightlines. The fighting was predictable, mundane. Kyle went down first, of course. Bots threw electricity beams, her squad blocked and dodged them. The same old routine.
Then things got mildly interesting. Adora got caught on a red platform, designed to descend quickly, like the ground in the real world would if it were blasted out underneath them. Catra watched her freeze for a second, her shoulders hunched up to her neck. Always bad with surprises, Catra thought with a mean smile. She shook her head. Stop being petty. She's your best friend. Adora stepped off the red platform just milliseconds before it dropped down, leaving a large hexagonal-shaped hole in the ground where she had just been.

The simulation continued, and Catra watched as the final bot rose out of the ground. It was large, about twenty times the size of the

other, and it towered over her squad. She couldn't see it herself, but she knew that through the VR goggles her team wore, they saw a hologram of the Queen, as obnoxiously pink as always. The bot shot a beam, and Lonnie and Rogelio dove out of the way. Adora, ever the skilled fighter, had recovered from her momentary shock with grace and leapt at the bot, her collapsible staff at the ready. It didn't take her long to dispatch the machine after she swung onto it's body; just a swift stabbing motion through the bot's guns and "head" – a round swiveling camera system containing it's processing units.

Catra jumped down from her position. The team hadn't done great today, except for Adora, as per usual. Catra considered that as she walked towards the giant bot, it's weird insect-looking legs stuck on the edges of the hole it had burst from. Adora always outdid everyone, it was just in her nature. Catra knew it stemmed from some deep desire to always be perfect, but just because she knew that didn't mean she really understood it.

Catra was the opposite of Adora in many ways. Where Adora was perfect, Catra was the screw-up. Where Adora was punctual, Catra showed up at the last possible second. Where Adora was kind, Catra was hard. The list went on. Normally, Catra didn't hold a grudge over Adora's lack of flaws, but she couldn't deny that sometimes, deep down, a little ugly part of her was satisfied when Adora failed every once in a while. It was horrible of her, she knew that, but it wasn't something she could really control. The best she could hope to do was bury it as deep as possible, and hope that Adora never developed the ability to read her thoughts.

When she arrived at the base of one of the robots legs, she placed a foot onto the cold metal and gently shoved. The metal creaked as the robot slipped, falling into the cavern below. A glance at Adora, and she noticed that the platform under the blonde girl had turned bright red. Ah. Catra smirked at her best friend and pointed a single finger at the ground below her. Before Adora even had a chance to react, the ground fell away beneath her, and she yelped in surprise.

The smirk on Catra's face widened into a grin as she made her way over to help the other girl out of the hole. She had used her staff to stop her fall, and she was hanging in the almost bottomless pit by one hand.

"Hey, Adora," Catra purred. "How's it hanging?"

"Catra." Adora did not sound impressed with Catra's teasing.

"Did you really show up late and let us do all the hard parts?" Her free hand swung out pleadingly, "That is low, even for you."

"Awwww." Catra narrowed her eyes, smiling even wider. "You know nothing's too low for me." She chuckled, a light teasing sound that always made Adora smile – no matter how annoyed she was with her.

"Now come on, you look stupid hanging down there."

Adora hesitated for a moment, but Catra could see the smile she was trying to hide. Overhead, a woman's voice came over the PA system, indicating that the training exercise had been completed.

Adora hung her belt up in her locker as Catra peeked over and laughed.

"You should've seen your face. You were like, 'Ah, no! Betrayal!'"

"Oh, come on, Catra. We're senior cadets now! I can't believe you're still pulling such childish, immature – is that a mouse?!"

Catra immediately responded, her tail bushing out and her head whipped up to look for the imaginary rodent. Adora couldn't help but laugh at the panicked, "What?! Where?!" from her friend.

"Are you ever going to not fall for that?" She asked after she finished laughing. It was an old prank between the two of them, going back to their earliest years in the Horde together. It was a hard place to grow up, and even harder still to live in as a senior

cadet. The lighthearted jokes and pranks could help take the edge off of it, but it didn't completely fill in the gaps. Honestly, some of the cadets didn't have anything to help them relax, let alone a best friend they could joke with. Adora didn't know what she'd do if she didn't have Catra, no matter how immature and irresponsible the other girl could be at times.

"I don't know," Catra sulked. "Are you ever going to let it go? That was one time."

"I know, but for some reason it's always funny," Adora leaned back against the lime green lockers.

"Adora," a saccharine voice interrupted them, as velvety as it was upsetting. The girls' guardian floated down the hallway, her pink and maroon capes flowing almost as much as her long black hair did in the non-existent wind.

"Shadow Weaver." Adora said, snapping to attention.

"You have done well." The jewel at the top of Shadow Weaver's red metal mask glinted. "You've completed your training course in record time."

Adora couldn't help the compulsion to correct her. As per usual, she felt the need to support and defend Catra, even if it collided with her deep need to be the best.

"Uh, well, that wasn't just me. You know, Catra did, too."

"Ah, yes," The distaste in Shadow Weaver's voice was palpable. "How someone as unmotivated as you," she looked directly at Catra, "completed the course in that time, I'll never know."

Catra rolled her eyes and casually replied, "Always serving up those pep talks, huh, Shadow Weaver?"

Adora cringed. Catra never could hold her tongue. She didn't have a lot of the same hold ups that Adora did when it came to authority. While Adora could never imagine sassing off to a

superior officer, Catra did it like it was her job. Adora would never say that Catra deserved the treatment Shadow Weaver gave her – rather, she'd say that Catra was definitely a victim there – but she definitely believed that Catra wouldn't be punished nearly half as much if she'd just learn to bite her tongue. Sometimes, it just seemed like Catra had a one-liner for everything.

Shadow Weaver's voice turned deadly. "Silence!" She hissed, sending chills up Adora's spine. "Do not be flippant with me, cadet."

"Sorry, Shadow Weaver," Catra said simply, not sounding sorry at all.

"Adora," the woman's change in tone was palpable. Where she had been all nails and spikes with Catra, her voice with Adora returned to that sickly sweet, velvety syrup. "Walk with me."
Adora started to follow, but then looked back at Catra. Her friend looked a little dejected, the same way she always did after a mild run-in with their guardian, but not too upset. Catra shrugged at her and nodded towards Shadow Weaver, indicating to Adora that she should follow the woman. Don't worry about me, Catra's eyes seemed to say. I'll be fine.

Adora hoped Catra could read the I'll be back as soon as I can and I'm sorry in her own eyes.
Shadow Weaver had already made it out of the locker room and into the outer corridor. She began speaking just as Adora caught up to her floating form.

"Lord Hordak has been watching you. He thinks you are a fine candidate for Force Captain."
Adora almost stopped in her tracks. Shock radiated into every corner of her body, followed by excitement. Force Captain? No way. But she was still so young, she still had so much left to perfect. She tried to keep her voice calm and even as she spoke.

"Really? Force Captain? Lord Hordak said that about me?"
electricity tingled in her fingertips.

“Oh, yes,” Shadow Weaver replied easily. “He sees great promise in you. In fact,” she waved a hand to the side, “he has elected you the honor of leading a squadron in the invasion of the rebel fortress of Thaymor.”

“Thaymor?” The electricity in her body ratcheted up. She was pretty sure that if they could plug her into the walls, she could single-handedly power the entirety of the Horde’s own fortress. “You mean, we’re finally seeing active duty?”

“You,” Shadow Weaver pointed a clawed, grey finger at Adora, “are seeing active duty.”

That caught Adora by surprise.

“But I’ll be able to bring my team along, right?”

“Your team is not ready. They’ll only slow you down.”

There was no way she could go into battle without her squad. They might have their faults, Catra with reliability, Lonnie with attitude, Rogelio with his bullheadedness, and Kyle with his… well, everything. Still, despite their faults, Adora had trained with them since she was a child. She knew how to fight with them, and she was good at her job because of them. She couldn’t go onto the battlefield in charge of a group of shoulders she didn’t know.

“Shadow Weaver, with respect, they’ve been training hard for this, too. And Catra, all she wants is to get out there and prove herself – “

Shadow Weaver interrupted her. “Then she should’ve worked harder to prove herself to me. This is what I raised you for, Adora.” Shadow Weaver turned towards her and raised her hands. A purplish-black orb of light spun into existence before poofing out into smoke. Where the ball had been now sat a green and yellow badge adorned with lime green bat wings – the Horde’s insignia.

“Now is your chance to prove yourself.” Adora took the badge from Shadow Weaver’s hand.

“I saw talent in you the moment I found you as an orphan child and took you in. Is this not what you’ve wanted since you were old enough to want anything?” Shadow Weaver guided Adora down the corridor to a window overlooking the Horde’s fortress. Metal buildings soared out of the ground towards the yellow sky, impressive in their size and number. A green glow washed over the bottom half of the buildings from the weapons forge, giving the buildings a strange, olive tinge.

“Yes,” Adora sighed. Shadow Weaver was right. This place was her home, and all she wanted to do was protect it. Here was her chance at that. So why did she feel so guilty about accepting the role? Catra would make her way up to Force Captain eventually; there was no reason for Adora to sacrifice her own career just because Catra had been irresponsible with hers.

“With you at the forefront, we will crush the Bright Moon Rebellion once and for all.” Shadow Weaver balled her hand into a fist in front of her face as she spoke. “Do not disappoint me.”
Adora stared out the window for a while after Shadow Weaver floated away, trying to assuage the guilt bubbling up into her chest.

Catra could see something was weighing on Adora. Despite the ridiculously high points on her red jackets shoulder pads – seriously, the things were nearly taller than the little bump thing she styled her bangs into – her shoulders were drooped and she was staring at her hands, turning something over almost methodically. Catra smiled deviously, a plan to bring a smile to her friend’s face forming in her head.

She climber up the omni-present metal pipes that lined the walls of the outdoor walkway, positioning herself at just the right position before pouncing onto Adora, pinning her to the ground. Adora grunted.

“Hey, what’d she say?” Catra asked, forcing her voice to sound excited. Shadow Weaver almost always pulled Adora to the side just to compliment her, and while she knew they made Adora happy, it was kind of hard to continually be excited for her when Catra herself received none of their guardian’s praise. It was selfish of her, sure. She was well aware that she had no right to begrudge Adora the compliments she received. So she faked her excitement for her. Besides, Adora always smiled when Catra encouraged her to talk about Shadow Weaver’s compliments, and Catra loved seeing Adora smile.

What else were best friends supposed to be for?

Something green caught Catra’s attention.

“Hey, what’s this?” She snatched the object out of Adora’s hands.

“Hey!” Adora objected. “Give it back!”

Catra leaped onto one of the larger metal pipes, bent in the middle to form a flat surface perfect for squatting on. She turned the green object over in her hand, and almost dropped it when she recognized it. A Force Captain badge?!

“No way! You’ve been promoted?” Catra held the badge aloft to underscore her words. Her best friend was a Force Captain! That was so cool. That meant… That meant they were going into the field! Catra was finally going to get the chance to prove that she wasn’t a slacker.

“Well, kind of.” Adora mumbled. “I mean, yeah, I guess.” She let out a small, nervous chuckle. “But, it’s not a big deal.”

Catra dropped down from her perch, landing softly on her feet.

“Are you kidding? That is awesome! We’re gonna see the world and conquer it!” Her excitement now was very real and very uncontrollable. She knew she was making a stupid face when she said “Adora, I need to blow something up.”

Adora cringed. “Ummm…”

“What?”

“Shadow Weaver,” Adora rubbed her arm, “says you’re not coming.”

“What? My time was just as good as yours today! What is her problem with me?”

“I mean,” Adora hesitated, “You are kind of disrespectful.”

“Why should I respect her? She’s just bitter that she doesn’t have any real power that doesn’t come from Hordak and everyone knows it.” Catra didn’t want to say why she really didn’t respect the Horde’s second-in-command. She had been shocked by too many of the sorceror’s magic bolts to count, and she really didn’t want to admit that they scared her a little. They weren’t like normal electricity. No, they rattled you down to your very core and made you forget who you were because the pain was just that intense. They were just as psychologically damaging as they were physically. Adora would never understand. Little Miss Perfect never made a mistake – at least, she never made one bad enough to warrant Shadow Weaver’s wrath. No, better to make it seem like Shadow Weaver was bitter, rather than Catra admitting she was scared.

That’s what Catra did best, after all. She buried her feelings and blustered angrily about others. It was the only way to keep herself from getting hurt. Adora definitely got a much clearer view of what Catra’s emotions were, but there were limits even to that. Catra could never let Adora know the real her, because Adora would leave. She would leave if she saw just how dark Catra could get sometimes, how mean and petty.

No, better to pretend like it was all Shadow Weaver’s fault instead of her own.

She finished off her tirade with a mean little dig at Adora, the only hint at the pettiness she buried way down deep.

“I guess it sure must be easy being a people pleaser like you.”

Adora frowned. “I am not a pe – “

Catra had already bounded off, trying to hide the tears that were welling in her eyes. She could hear Adora behind her begging her to wait.

It took Adora a while to reach where Catra was sitting, mostly because she didn’t have the same feline ability to climb wherever she wanted like Catra did. Hmph, Catra thought glumly. At least I’m better than her at one thing. She immediately regretted the bitter thought when Adora immediately apologized to her.

“Look, I’m sorry.” She began. “I didn’t even think you wanted to be a Force Captain.”

That stung a little. Of course, Catra couldn’t blame her for thinking that. They both had very different ideas of what it meant to be loyal soldiers. While Adora relished in the routine work that the army provided her, Catra despised it. She knew that she was much better suited to the actual fighting aspect of army-life than she was to the mundane repetition of training. Whatever.

“I don’t,” She lied. “Here, take your stupid badge.” Adora wouldn’t understand why Catra wanted to be a Force Captain. She barely understood it herself. All she knew is that she wanted it. Maybe it was a desire for a approval, maybe it was a desire to take that badge and shove against Shadow Weaver’s stupid mask and say, hah, look, I’m not completely worthless after all. Either way, it didn’t matter. She wasn’t going to get promoted anytime soon.

“Come on, Catra,” Adora pleaded. “This is what I have been working for my entire life. I was hoping you could be, I don’t know, happy for me.”

Guilt poked its way into Catra’s chest, ice-cold daggers melting the hot anger she felt towards Adora and Shadow Weaver. Ugh. She was being a terrible friend to Adora. Instead of celebrating her

friend's success, she was sulking on the roof of the Horde's tallest building and making her friend chase after her to cheer her up.

"Ugh, whatever, it's not like I even care," Catra said, desperately trying to hide how much she actually did care.

"I just wanna get out of this dump at some point before I die of boredom." She flopped over from her sitting position to lie of her back, her arms dangling off the sides of the pole she was laying on.

"I wonder what's even outside the Fright Zone anyway."

She hated the way the Fright Zone looked at night. While it was fine during the day, the sun washing out the sickly green glow that seemed to cover all of the buildings, at night, it was just downright disgusting. The pipes and buildings all looked half rotten, falling over onto themselves in weird shapes and patterns. Dark, foul-smelling smoke rose from various points throughout the city, obfuscating the sky and making it difficult to see any of the moons floating just above the city. Gross.

She didn't know how anyone could find this place beautiful, but if her instructors were right, Bright Moon was worse. She wanted to see that for herself, find out if that really was true. Unfortunately, it seemed like she was destined to be forever stuck in her own personal hell while her best friend was able to see the world she was so desperate to see and liberate. Petty thoughts. Box them up. She chastised herself.

She felt Adora's body twitch beside her. A quick glance at her face revealed a devilish smirk that the blonde girl rarely wore. Miss Perfect was rarely devilish. Oh, this was gonna be good.

"Why don't we go find out?" She asked, holding up a metal skiff key.

"I take it back!" Catra shouted over the wind. "You're officially awesome! I can't believe you actually stole a skiff!"

“Borrowed!” Adora corrected. “Please don’t make me regret this.”

The skiff was a light vessel, with no top and as they sailed over the land, wind whipped at her hair. Sand and dirt blasted up at her face, skinning it, but she couldn’t care less. This was the farthest away from Shadow Weaver she had ever been in her life, and she wasn’t going to let anything ruin it.

“I’ve always wanted to drive one of these things. Here, gimme.” Catra reached out a hand to grab the skiff’s guidestick – a long pole with a handle that directed the skiff’s paddle. She knocked Adora over lightly, taking control of the vehicle herself.

“Whoah, there,” Adora held out a hand in warning, “save us some fuel to get back.”

“That is a problem for future Adora and Catra.” Catra bore down on the thrust, pushing the skiff as fast as it would go. Adora tried to take back control of the vehicle but Catra wasn’t willing to give up this newfound freedom just yet. They tussled, grabbing the guidestick back and forth, the skiff wobbling wildly. It wasn’t until something loomed right in front of them that they quit their shenanigans in favor of actually being responsible skiff drivers. Catra backed off, letting Adora take control of the vehicle, but she kept her hand right next to Adora’s on the guidestick. Couldn’t let her suddenly decide to turn around and go home, after all.

They were surrounded by trees, tall and twisted and beautiful. Beautiful, little colored orbs hung from the branches above, as well as an assortment of flowers and other vegetation. Below them, the grass grew in a thick, luscious carpet, waving as the slight breeze gently blew over it. The air smelled sweet, like the honey Catra had stolen from Shadow Weaver’s room as a child. It was quiet, except for the sound of their breathing and the breeze rustling the leaves on the branches.

“What is it?” Catra asked a little breathlessly.

"I think," Adora began, a little hesitantly, "this must be the Whispering Woods."

No way. Catra was stunned. There was no way that this beautiful place was the nightmare land that the Horde had been scaring them with since childhood. But even as she said it, she could sort of see the resemblance to the images that were pasted all over the Horde's screens. Still, where the Horde's drawings showed gnarled, dead trees with rotten vegetation scattered across the ground and evil princesses lurking around every corner, the reality seemed significantly different. These trees, while gnarled, didn't really appear foreboding and evil. They looked almost… soft? Like if she were to press a hand against their bark, they would feel like the velvet of Shadow Weaver's cloak. The lush vegetation looked comfortable enough to sleep on, and it didn't seem like there were any princesses waiting to ambush them. It seemed peaceful, quiet. Like they were the only ones there.

"They say there are stange, old monsters in there, and – and the trees move when you're not looking."
Catra knew Adora was only talking to calm herself down. She always did that when frustrated – repeated obvious facts or stories they both knew. Catra figured it was probably a way for Adora to maintain a little control, in the same way that burying her own emotions helped Catra.

Adora continued, "Every Horde squadron they've sent in there has never come out again."

Catra had heard all of the same stories growing up. Of course, it wasn't entirely true – people went in and out of the Woods all the time. It was the ones who went too deep that got lost. Plenty of Horde soldiers had gone deep into the Woods only to disappear forever. Others had only gone a little bit in, enough to see what the Woods were like, but not far enough to lose sight of the forest's edge. It was a little bit of a sore spot for most Horde soldiers. Everyone wanted to go into the Woods to fight, but they all knew they probably weren't going to come back alive. Depressing? Yes. Exciting and mysterious? To Catra, also yes.

“Let’s go in.” She said, unable to suppress her excitement.

“Wait, what?” Adora, but before she could react further, Catra pushed down on the throttle, and they sped forward.

It was hard navigating through the woods, and it took a lot more concentration on Catra’s part than out in the open, but it was fun. She couldn’t go nearly as fast as she wanted to, but she settled for making the skiff swoop through the trees in wild arcs, bouncing Adora around when she fell to the floor of the skiff.

Catra whooped in excitement. Adora yelled in fear.

“Catra, slow down!” She cried.

A dark, looming shadow appeared before them. For a split second, the irrational part of Catra’s brain thought that the Queen had found them, but that thought cleared out quickly when Adora shouted,

“Catra, tree! Tree!” and pulled up on the guidestick as far as it would go.

They shot up in the air in a direction that skiffs were decidedly not built to go. The vehicle shuddered under the strain and bounced against tree after tree.

The skiff knocked against one tree particularly hard, and Catra felt herself lose balance. Her hand slipped off of the guidestick, and she felt herself fall. In the distance, she heard Adora calling her name. The ground was coming towards her fast, and when she landed, her vision went black.

When Catra woke up, she was alone. The woods around her seemed darker than they had before, almost dreamlike. She was lying in a bed of soft grass and weeds that rubbed against her skin like velvet. Birds chirped in the trees, an annoying sound that made Catra’s head spin.

She sat up rubbing the back of her neck.

“Adora?” Catra called out quietly. There was no sign of the blonde, only the distant chirping of birds and the humming of insects.

Something caught her eye. Ahead of her, snarled in a tangle of strange purple roots was a sword. It was large, with a wider blade than most, and it had a golden hilt that fanned out like the feathers on a bird. A blue stone about the size of her palm was embedded at the base of the hilt. Light shone down around the space, sunlight breaking through a bald patch in the trees above, probably, but Catra couldn’t help but admire how well it framed the scene in front of her.

It was enchanting, really. The blade sparkled like new in the light, glinting gold and silver and blue. She had never seen anything like it.

“Whoa.” She couldn’t help herself. She had to touch it.

Moving hurt. Her body was definitely wrecked from her long fall, but the urge in her gut that the sword was hers was too strong to resist.

She made her way over to the sword, slow but determined. As she got closer, the sparkling of the metal only got more intense, and the light filtering down through the trees became brighter.

“Cool.”

She reached out a hand, intending to touch the blade’s pommel, but as soon as she made contact with it, a blinding flash of light forced her onto the ground.

The forest in front of her disappeared. Images flicked through her brain like the slideshows her instructors showed before training simulations. A strange series of orbs, the Whispering Woods from a bird’s eye view, a strange glowing stone. The sword, free of the roots it had been tangled in.

“Balance must be restored.” A soft, female voice spoke in Catra’s mind. “Etheria must seek a hero.”

More images of a ruin, a strange girl with flowing blonde hair, a crying baby.

“Catra.” The lady was in front of her, now. She was tall, with white eyebrows and a cape, but before Catra could observe much more, she vanished into blackness.

“Catra.” The lady’s voice faded.

“Catra! Hey, Catra!” Adora’s voice sounded panicked as Catra opened her eyes. “Catra!”

“Adora?” Catra’s body hurt even worse now, and her head was pounding. She couldn’t get the image of the lady with the cape out of her mind. “What happened?”

“You fell out of the skiff!” Adora was definitely on the verge of panicking. Catra rubbed a hand over her eyes, hoping to push down the headache that had formed right behind her temple. “Are you okay?”

“Yeah, I’m fine.” Catra was not fine. Her head hurt. Her body hurt. The sounds of the birds that had been mildly annoying before now felt like daggers stabbing at her brain.

“Come on, let’s go. I knew this was a bad idea.”

Catra rolled her eyes but sat up anyways. She looked to where the snarled roots had been, hoping to retrieve the sword before they left, but there was nothing there.

“Wait. Did you move that sword?”

“What sword?”

“The sword. You know, big, gold, shiny. It was over there. Impossible to miss.” She pointed to where she had seen the

weapon earlier, but her hand sank when she realized there was nothing in the clearing, not even the weird purple roots that had acted as a stand for the sword.

"Catra, are you sure you're okay? Did you hit your head on the way down?"

"No! I didn't hit my head! I swear, there was a sword over there! I touched it and it flashed a bunch of light and then- "

"Oh no, you did hit your head, didn't you? Can you at least keep it together in front of Shadow Weaver so she doesn't find out?"

Catra frowned. How had Adora not seen the huge flash of light? Catra was pretty sure that it would have been visible all the way from Brightmoon, if not the Fright Zone.

"Whatever, let's just get out of here." She spat.

The two girls hopped onto the skiff, and Adora steered them off. Catra kept her eyes on the clearing until long after it had disappeared behind the thick forest foliage.

Catra managed to bury her confusion for the rest of the day. Through meals, and roll calls, and bed checks, she maintained her trademark cavalier attitude towards authority. She smirked and simpered her way through the day, and she even managed to trick Adora into thinking everything was okay.

It wasn't until that night, when she was sleeping in her normal position at the foot of Adora's bed, that her strange experience in the Woods caught up with her.

She dreamed of the sword, and of the blinding flash of light that it had produced. The lady's voice returned to her, speaking her name over and over.

"Catra. Catra. Catra!"

Catra shot awake, breathing hard. At the top of the flimsy foam mattress, Adora was sound asleep. It didn't take much for Catra to slide off of the bunk quietly and slip into the hallway.

"Hey," Adora's voice was quiet, but it still caught Catra off guard. "Where are you going?"

"Nowhere important." Catra replied, whispering harshly. "I'll be back in a bit."

Adora snuck out into the hallway and grabbed Catra's wrist.

"I'm serious. Where are you going?"

Catra sighed, her eyes rolling up to the ceiling.

"The Woods. I saw something out there that I need to deal with."

"Catra! You can't just sneak off to the Woods!" Adora's whisper was beginning to sound more like a strained shout.

"Why not? We did it earlier." Catra continued quickly, not giving Adora a chance to interject. "Besides, I'll be back before anyone even knows I left."

Adora's hand came up to her face, rubbing her temple.

"I'm just worried, Catra. What happens if you get caught?"

Catra shrugged.

"Nothing worse than usual, I guess."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

Catra shook her head, not wanting to get distracted from her mission.

"Nothing. Forget about it. Look," she grabbed Adora's hand with her own. "I'll be back before tomorrow morning. Go back to bed. I don't want you getting into trouble because of me." She finished

off her statement with a smile, hoping it would be enough to help Adora relax.

Adora's shoulders sagged in defeat.

"Alright, fine. But I'm not covering for you tomorrow! If you're late, that's on you."

Catra smirked.

"It's always on me when I'm late."

She turned and ran off before Adora had a chance to respond.

The Woods were a thousand times more confusing under the light of the moons. Catra couldn't seem to find her way through the brush. Anytime she thought she had figured out a path, the Woods reshaped themselves around her, a constantly changing labyrinth that made it impossible to find her way through.

There were noises all around her, too. Birds and animals chirped and chittered from every direction, and each new sound send a shot of adrenaline through her heart. She was pretty sure most of the childhood ghost stories the Horde had told her about the Woods were just exaggerations, but she still jumped anytime a twig snapped under her bare feet.

Regret was coursing through her body in waves. She shouldn't have gone out alone. How stupid was she? She was going to get killed by some crazy animal or worse, a rogue princess. She was debating the merits of turning around and heading back to the Fright Zone – and Adora – when something caught her eye.

One of the purplish trees in front of her had a large gash taken out of its side, an injury that could have only been caused by an incredibly large animal or weapon.

Or a wayward skiff as it spun out of control.

About twenty yards in front of her, through the brush and trees, bright blue light shone like a beacon, calling her forward. Just the sight of the light was enough to quiet most of her internal ramblings, and for the first time since she had seen the vision of that beautiful sword, her mind was quiet.

She made her way through the brush, picking over wayward roots and stones, careful to not fall. The light seemed to get more intense as she grew closer, washing over her body like sunlight.

Pushing aside some leaves, she stumbled into a clearing that was a bright as midday despite the fact that it was the middle of the night. In front of her sat the sword, snarled in its bed of purple tree roots.

Catra's feet moved forward of their own accord, her hand stretched out towards the blade.

She didn't hear the other voices in the clearing until it was almost too late.

"The tracker pad says otherwise." A masculine voice said, full of exasperation.

"It's *this* way-" The lighter, more shrill voice cut off with a gasp.

Catra snapped to attention. There were two people in the clearing. A girl with strange, glittering purple and pink hair, and a clothing ensemble to match was staring at Catra with her jaw nearly on the floor. Well, at least Catra wasn't the only one taken by surprise. That put them on more of an even playing field. Catra squared her shoulders, ready for a fight. Next to the pink-haired girl was a taller boy with broad shoulders and a bow slung over his back. Damn. They were armed.

Years of training had led Catra to this very moment. In a split second, her brain ran through all possible ways this could end. She could engage in direct combat, but given the presence of the bow across the guy's shoulders, she didn't know if it was a good idea to risk a direct fight. Not in a two-on-one combat situation,

where the two had weapons and she was alone. Catra was tempted to kick herself for not bringing a stun rifle, at the very least. Option two, she could run. Hopefully, the two rebels would let her go, and even if they didn't, Catra was pretty fast on her feet regardless. She could escape through the treetops if she needed.

But that would mean leaving behind the sword, the whole reason she had made this hare-brained trip.

Option three, then.

Catra reacted before the rebels had a chance to get a word out, turning on her feet quickly and sprinting for the sword. Her opponents shrieked, but Catra knew they wouldn't be able to reach her in time. She kept running, blocking out all distractions.

She was almost there when a flash of sparkles surrounded the sword, and the pink-haired girl materialized in front of Catra. Fuck. They weren't just rebels. The girl was a princess. Catra realized she was going to have to engage in direct combat if she wanted to take the sword with her. She lunged for the girl, but before she could grab her, the girl disappeared in another flash of sparkles.

Catra grunted in frustration.

The girl rematerialized a few feet away and tossed the sword to her partner.

"Bow, catch!"

Bow, the aptly named sharpshooter, was in the midst of knocking back and arrow when the sword fell in front of him, forcing him to drop his weapon in order to catch it.

Catra sprinted towards him, but Sparkles materialized on her back before she made it farther than a few feet. The princess began pulling at Catra's hair, trying to disorient her. It was incredibly ineffective.

Catra flexed her claws before digging them into the girl's arms before throwing Sparkles over her shoulder. Sparkles landed with a thud on the ground. Catra left her there, getting down on all fours to sprint after Bow, who was currently attempting to run out of the clearing. When she was within a few feet of him, she pounced, knocking the boy off of his feet. The sword skittered across the clearing.

Catra stood to run, but Sparkles materialized in front of her again.

"I'll hurt you if I have to," Catra announced, eyeing the bleeding claw marks she had left of Sparkles' upper arm.

"Duh, that's what you Horde soldiers do." Sparkles spit out before throwing an explosive ball of glitter magic at Catra's feet.

Catra pushed her way through the glittery cloud, and saw Sparkles reaching for the sword. She jumped, throwing all of her weight forward onto the pink-haired girl. When she turned to grab the sword herself, Bow jumped on top of her, forming a three-person pile of punching and tearing and fighting. Catra's claws were fully out, slashing and hacking at anything they came in contact with.

It took a lot of effort on her part, but eventually, Catra was able to maneuver herself into a position where, if she reached her arm out just right, she could touch the sword.

The tip of her finger brushed across the bright blue stone in the sword's hilt, and the clearing erupted into dazzling white light.

In front of her, the white light condensed into a single column of rainbow, almost blinding her. The room around her was strange, covered in odd crystalline structures engraved with words in an alphabet that she recognized even though she knew she had never seen it before. She wasn't sure how she had gotten here, when just moments before she had been in the middle of the clearing, but she realized she had much more pressing matters to

attend to when a familiar female voice spoke to her from the column of light.

"Hello, Catra." The same woman from before appeared in front of her. Catra hadn't realized how tall the woman had been the first time she had seen her, but now she realized that the woman had to be well over eight feet tall. She was almost entirely purple, with a floor length purple dress and matching cape, and her purple skin. Her white eyebrows stood out in sharp contrast to her angular face.

"Who are you? Where am I? What did you do to me?" The questions shot out of Catra's mouth before she could stop them. The light surrounding the woman had faded. No, not faded – dispersed. It was now lighting up the entirety of the room she was in, highlighting the strange engravings on the crystalline purple walls.

"My name is Light Hope. I have been waiting a long time for you, but I could not reach you until you forged your connection with the sword."

Catra backed up involuntarily. The woman's voice sounded vaguely robotic, like a fancier version of the announcement program they blared over the PA system every morning in the Fright Zone.

"Why? What connection? Why is the sword important?" Catra was starting to get a little freaked out. What did this weird, tall lady want with her. In front of her, the lady's image glitched.

Okay, not a lady. A hologram.

"The sword is meant for you." Light hope waved her hand, and a hologram of the sword appeared in front of Catra, it's tip pointed toward the sky. Catra reached for it unconsciously, and the image glitched where her hand came in contact with the light.

"Etheria has need of you, Catra. Will you answer its call? Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?" Light Hope had moved, and was

now almost directly in front of Catra, standing just behind the image of the sword.

“I’m not fighting for anyone but myself.”

“You must fight. Etheria depends on it.” Light Hope didn’t seem fazed by Catra’s refusal. “Do not let your fears cloud your judgement.”

“Pssh, I’m not afraid.”

“You are.” Light Hope started to move backwards, the bright light behind her fading. “Soon, you will understand.”

“Wait, where are you going?”

Light Hope faded into the light behind her, before everything in the room collapsed; a hallucination that folded neatly into itself and disappeared, leaving Catra alone in the pitch blackness.

She woke to find her hands bound with rope, and her head pounding.

“Hey, she’s awake!” Bow shouted directly in Catra’s ear.

“What…? Where’s Light Hope?”

Sparkles was frowning at her, a strangely harsh look that Catra had to admit did not fit the soft roundness of the girl’s features. Her arm was wrapped around the sword, keeping it secure in her grasp.

“Quiet, Horde spy, I ask the questions.” Catra detected a slight tremor in Sparkles’ voice. She didn’t sound scared… No, she sounded excited. Catra almost rolled her eyes at that.

“How did you make it this far into the Whispering Woods?”

Catra didn’t respond.

“Answer me!” Sparkles was two seconds away from shrieking. Goodness, this girl really didn’t know how to handle her adrenaline.

Catra shrugged.

“You said be quiet. I was being quiet.”

Sparkles groaned, putting her hand over her face.

“Fine, you are permitted to speak, but only to answer my questions. Got it?”

Catra shrugged, a noncommittal response that she hoped would get under Sparkles’ skin. Sparkles’ eye twitched. Catra suppressed a smile. It seemed as if the princess didn’t handle annoyance very well, and if there was one thing Catra was good at, it was being annoying.

“Now, answer my question.”

“What was your question?”

“My *question*, which you should totally still remember, was how did you make it this far into the Woods?”

“Oh, that question. Yeah, I just walked. You know, one foot in front of the other. Very easy. You should try it sometime. Probably a lot less draining than that teleporting thing you do.”

Bow spoke up before Sparkles had the chance to respond.

“Oh, Glimmer, do you need to recharge?”

“Bow!”

“What? That was a lot of magic you used there. I don’t want you getting drained.”

Catra snorted.

“You have to recharge?” She cocked an eyebrow at Glimmer.

“Look, Bow, can we not discuss this in front of our prisoner?”

Bow seemed to realize his mistake, and he looked at the ground sheepishly. Catra filed that little princess tidbit away for later. Maybe she could try to wear down the princess’ magic tap and make her run out of magic. That might make escape easier. Idly, she extended a claw and began to surreptitiously work at the ropes around her wrist. She didn’t know what time it was, but she knew she needed to escape soon if she wanted to make it back to the Fright Zone before she got caught.

Sparkles, Glimmer, whatever her name was, turned back towards Catra.

“Fine, so you said you just ‘walked’ in. So that means that you just so happened to find yourself in the Whispering Woods, like you just so happened to try and steal out sword.” Sparkles was angry now, no longer excited. Her voice was hard, on the border of yelling. She lifted the sword by the hilt to punctuate her statement.

Anger flashed through Catra. She didn’t like being called a thief.

“Hey, it’s not yours. It’s mine.”

“The Whispering Woods is under the Rebellion’s protection. You were lucky to make it as far as you did. Come on, Bow, let’s get this spy back to Bright Moon where she can be interrogated properly.”

Sparkles pushed Bow off to the edge of the clearing, and the two began exchanging whispers. Every so often, Sparkles would raise the sword a little bit with excitement. Catra felt her heart leap every time she saw the sword move. She didn’t know why, but she felt like it was her job to take care of it and make sure no one broke it.

Beneath her claw, the first layer of rope snapped and fell away. Only two more to go.

She was halfway through sawing the second piece of rope when the two rebels returned.

“Come on, on your feet.” Sparkles gritted out, sword gripped in her hand with the point of the blade facing down. Catra had the urge to reach out and flip the sword the right way in Sparkles’ hand. She didn’t, of course, but she couldn’t deny that the urge was there.

They walked for a while through the Woods, so long that Catra’s bare feet started getting a little sore.

“You positive we’re going the right way, Glimmer?” Bow asked gently.

In front of Catra, Sparkles was leading the group with a tracker pad. How a tracker pad was supposed to work in an everchanging map, Catra had no clue. She was only worried about getting back to the Horde once she escaped, not about how lost her two captors got.

“I know what I’m doing, Bow. Can you please just trust me for once?”

Catra snorted.

“Trouble in paradise?” She asked Bow.

“You have no idea.” He replied to Catra under his breath.

Hm. It seemed like archer boy might have a sense of humor. Interesting.

Bow spoke up again, this time to Sparkles.

“You know I always trust you, but I’m starting to get a little freaked out. I mean, I pretty much grew up in these Woods, and I’ve never seen this part of them.”

Catra honestly couldn’t tell the difference between the Woods they were in now versus the ones they had been in earlier. The same purple trees grew around them with the same strange flora draped over their branches. The grass below her feet was the same soft texture it had been before, and around her, the same animal sounds kept her on alert. It all looked the same. She wasn’t quite sure what the fuss was. The whole Whispering Woods were dangerous, not just the unknown parts.

“I’ve heard stories about weird stuff out here.” Bow finished, and Catra almost scoffed. There was no way the stories he had heard compared to any of the ghost stories she and Adora had been raised on.

“It’s fine, okay? Just let me figure this out.” Sparkles definitely had an attitude, and she dematerialized as if to punctuate her point.

“Okay! Touchy,” Bow rolled his eyes, and used his weapon to push back some branches before they could snag in Catra’s hair. She didn’t say thank you.

“Sorry ‘bout her. Usually she’s really nice.”

Catra rolled her eyes.

“Sure, she is. To you. Not to someone like me.”

“Well, yeah, I guess. Still, though, she really is a lot nicer to most people.”

“But not to Horde soldiers?”

Bow rubbed the back of his neck.

“I don’t know. This is the longest we’ve ever been around a Horde soldier before.”

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Seriously, we've only ever been in one fight before, and that was mostly a retreat."

Wow, no wonder Sparkles had been so excited before. She was a really green soldier. Were princesses soldiers? Or were they generals? Either way, Catra decided, she was young and inexperienced. Catra filed that next to her little note about the recharging.

Sparkles was busy teleporting around the forest in front of them, shaking her tracker pad in frustration. Catra had to admit that she didn't *seem* evil – at least, not in the way that her training instructors had always told her. There were no fangs or blood red eyes or dried blood crusted to her hands. Honestly, the only blood Catra could see was around the places where Catra had clawed her arms to shreds.

Weird.

Catra really wouldn't have been surprised if everything they had been taught about the princesses had been a lie. She had watched Shadow Weaver lie to everyone around her for years, especially Adora. Manipulation was the Horde's whole thing. It would only make sense that they would try to villainize their enemies by making them seem like bloodthirsty monsters.

She was almost done clawing through the third rope around her wrist when she decided to leave it. The thing was eviscerated enough that if she needed to escape, she could just snap the few remaining strands with a sharp thrust of her wrists over her thigh. If she broke all the way through now, her captors would probably just get new ropes and she'd have to start all over again.

"Can I ask you a question?" Bow started tentatively.

Catra didn't verbally respond, instead inclining her head slightly, a move that she hoped said *If you must*.

“It’s just, you don’t seem like a bad person. Maybe a little snarky, but not bad or evil. So why do you work for the Evil Horde?”

That question caught Catra by surprise.

“Who calls us that?”

“Um, everyone?”

“Why?”

“Because you guys are evil?”

Bow sounded confused, and Catra didn’t blame him.

“You want the real story?” Catra didn’t know why she felt the urge to explain herself to this boy. Maybe it was because he was being nicer to her than anyone had been in a long time, outside of Adora. Maybe it was because she had gotten brain damage when she fell out of the skiff. Either way, it didn’t matter. She was going to run away soon regardless. Who cared if they knew her sad backstory?

“I work for them because they took me in as a kid. I don’t like them, but it’s all I know, you know?”

As soon as she said it, she regretted it. Bow’s eyes went glassy and round, as if he were about to cry.

“Whatever, kid. Don’t get sentimental about it.”

Bow wiped at his eyes.

“Okay, okay, it’s just… That’s so sad!”

Catra went back to her favorite avoidance tactic – sarcasm.

“Yeah, yeah, I cry myself to sleep every night, wailing for the family who left me behind. Very tragic.”

“Can I ask you one more question?”

Catra groaned.

“No, this one won’t be invasive, I swear.”

“Fine.”

“It’s just. Everyone who’s ever met a Horde soldier says that the soldiers hate them on sight. Why is that? What do they tell you about us in the Horde?”

She thought about mentioning the princess propaganda to Bow but decided against it. Regardless of whether it was true or not, it didn’t matter. It wasn’t going to change her mind. She needed to get back to the Fright Zone, and back to Adora. Maybe when she got back, if she decided that she was done with the Horde and their lies, she could convince Adora to leave with her. They could run away together and find happiness somewhere else.

“They tell us you’re evil. That you’re destroying the planet. That it’s our duty to save the world. Just typical manipulation stuff.”

Bow gasped.

“So, they lie to you? And you know they’re lying?” His voice got quiet. “Why do you stay?”

Catra sighed. It seemed like she was destined to bear her heart and soul to this strange boy tonight. The boy who had take her captive.

“I stay because it’s all I know, and because my friend would be heartbroken if I left.”

Sparkles chose that exact moment to whimper, a heartbroken sound that cut through the strange bubble of calm comfort that Bow had managed to wrap around Catra.

Catra looked up.

In front of them lay the remains of a devastated village. Buildings torn apart by artillery, trees toppled by plasma beams, and other municipal artifacts were sprawled across the destroyed forest floor. Scorched remains of cottages rose out of the ground like tombstones.

Next to Catra, Bow reached down and picked up a painted fresco off of the ground, a frown on his face. He turned to Catra.

"The Horde did this. This is what they do."

"Don't act like you didn't already know." Sparkles spit out. "I bet you were a part of the raiding party that did this."

"No, I wasn't. I've never seen active combat." Catra didn't know why she wanted to defend herself. She didn't actually care what these rebels thought of her.

Didn't she?

"Look, the Horde does this." Bow said, valiantly trying – and failing – to keep the anger in his voice subdued. "They tear apart families and homes, all for what? What are they fighting for?"

"They say they're fighting for Etheria." Catra growled, knowing well enough that it wasn't true. The fresco in Bow's hand was scratched, a deep gash cut in between a tall, parental figure and smaller, child-like figure. Her heart broke of its own accord.

Sparkles grabbed Catra by the wrist, dragging her deeper into the wreckage.

"What about this is `*fighting for Etheria*'? They're destroying the world, and they're tearing people apart in the process. This is what you're fighting for?"

Catra shook her head, dread building in her stomach. No, she didn't want to tear little kids apart from their families. She had been torn apart from her family, and that had only led to

heartbreak and distress. No, she was fighting to stay with Adora. She wasn't fighting for the Horde. She was fighting for her friend.

"No… No, I don't fight for them. I don't!" her voice was desperate. She needed these people to understand. She wasn't hurting families in the way she had been hurt. She needed them to know that if it weren't for Adora, she wouldn't have stayed. She would have left long ago. How was she supposed to explain that to these rebels? How was she supposed to say "Yeah, I keep fighting for an evil regime because I'm too scared of being alone,".

In front of them, a Horde bot lay in ruins.

"You're a heartless destroyer, just like all the rest of your people," Glimmer's voice was cold, angry.

"I am not a destroyer. I told you, I've never even seen active combat!" Catra was pleading, for her life and for her dignity. She knew she couldn't defend the Horde, but maybe she could defend herself.

"You work for them!" Glimmer shouted. "Ever since the Horde got here, they've been poisoning our land, burning our cities, destroying everything in their path. And you're a part of it!"

Catra was stunned into silence. Glimmer was right. By staying in the Horde, she was supporting this destruction. She wondered if her own family had been one of the ones torn apart by the Horde. Had someone like her been responsible for her own family's deaths? If that person had chosen to defect, would Catra even be in the Horde today?

A faceless image of her parents rose in her mind. She didn't remember them, but she imagined they looked like her. Short, thin, wiry, with brown ears and a tail. She imagined siblings, running around in the Woods, laughing. Her heart hurt. Someone had taken these faceless ghosts from her, and if she stayed in the Horde, she was destined to take that same thing away from another child.

She was destined to damn other children to her life.

She couldn't do that.

She couldn't.

She needed to get back to the Fright Zone, and back to Adora. Maybe when she got back, she could convince Adora to leave with her. They could run away together and find happiness somewhere else. They didn't have to keep contributing to the destruction the Horde was wreaking. It would take some convincing to get Adora to run away, though. Maybe Catra could steal another skiff and bring her friend here. Surely if Adora saw the destruction, she would want to leave, too. They could run away from the war, and just be safe.

Not tearing apart other people's families.

Catra's heart was tearing in her chest.

Glimmer had stormed off, leaving Bow and Adora alone.

"Hey," Bow put his hand on Catra's shoulder. "It's okay. I said it earlier – you don't seem like a bad person. It's not to late to change."

Glimmer screamed before Catra had the chance to respond.

"There's something out there. Something big." She was running back towards Catra and Bow, the sword held in front of her like she expected to use it as a shield.

"How big?" Bow asked, readying his weapon.

The ground rumbled around them, a feeling like an earthquake spreading through the Woods. The three of them collapsed under the tremors. In front of them, from where Glimmer had just come back, a giant bug-like monster rose out of the ground.

The thing was ugly, Catra decided. Big, grey, with bright blue eyes and puke green details. Most importantly, though, it was huge. Easily thirty feet tall. She snapped the restraint ropes on her wrist, thankful for her own foresight.

“So, pretty big then.” Bow said, sounding none-too-happy about that realization.

The big bug was coming towards them at an impressive speed, with its many legs moving in rapid succession. It shrieked, bringing a sharp foot up over Glimmer as if to stab down at her and crush her. She dematerialized milliseconds before it made contact, rematerializing in a nearby tree and jumping onto the bug, blasting it with a magic glitter bomb. Catra found herself really hoping the princess wasn’t too low on her magic.

It didn’t do much, and the bug kept stomping at them, an ironic situation that was not lost on Catra. She wasn’t sure what best course of action was. On one hand, she could probably claw out the bug’s eyes, but that would be really risky and would involve her getting up close and personal with Ugly. On the other hand, she could run.

Before she had the chance to decide, though, her ankle slipped into a crevice in the ground, one of the ones created when the bug erupted through the soil. She almost lost her balance and was worried that the bug was going to get her, but Bow stepped in between her and Ugly, weapon drawn. He fired an arrow that emitted a strange, sticky, green substance that coated the bug’s mouth.

“Thanks,” She said, breathlessly.

“Don’t mention it.”

Glimmer started hammering at the bug with magical glitter bombs, and Catra was finding herself genuinely worried the girl was going to wear herself out. She needed to help. Bow had just

saved her life, after all. She figured she owed him. She began working on freeing her foot while the rebels worked on the bug.

It didn't take long for the bug to overcome Glimmer's magic attack, and it kicked her hard, throwing her back against one of the trees. Catra was pretty sure that if Glimmer wasn't a princess, that blow would've been deadly.

Bow released arrow after arrow on Ugly, a torrent of ammo that seemed to be having almost no effect.

Catra finally freed her foot. Out of the corner of her eye, the sparkling gold of the sword's hilt caught her attention. She dove for the blade, knowing somehow that this would work.

In front of her, Bow got thrown into a tree, at a slightly slower velocity than Glimmer had been.

Catra held the sword aloft. It didn't light up into a blazing glow this time, just sat cold and silent in her hands. Still, the weight felt like it belonged there. It almost felt like a part of her that had been missing for a very long time. Glimmer was back up again, desperately throwing those magic blasts like she didn't have an already depleted magic reserve.

In Catra's hands, the sword had an electric shock run down the blade.

"Come on, work for me." Catra grunted. "Just… do your stupid light up thingy, or whatever."

The sword did nothing.

"Please," Catra's voice was getting a little desperate.

Bow and Glimmer were curled together on the ground, trying to protect themselves.

"Hey, Ugly!" Catra called out. She felt the need to protect the rebels, even though they had taken her captive. One of them had

been nicer to her than anyone outside of Adora had been in a long time.

She held the sword out with two hands, pointing it at the bug. Ugly scuttled towards her, an ugly leg stretched out. It touched the sword, and light flashed.

Catra saw what she thought was Bright Moon, then the Crimson Waste and something crashing, then a strange crystal building. Light Hope appeared. Behind her, a portal and a crying baby.

Light Hope's voice echoed in her mind, and Catra wasn't sure if it was a memory or if the strange lady had somehow managed to hack her brain.

"Catra. Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?"

Her words rang in Catra's head, and suddenly, Catra knew what she needed to do.

She held the sword aloft with one hand, pointing it directly at the sky and said the words Light Hope had been trying to pull from her this entire time.

"For the honor… of Grayskull!"

Everything changed in an instant. She felt a strange burning sensation in her limbs. It wasn't unpleasant, more like how she felt after a long workout. She felt like she was being stretched out, made into *more* of her. She was surrounded in a strange rainbow of light, and it was almost blinding. Her vision was strange, too. It felt sharper, like she could see more clearly than ever before.

When the light faded, she realized the bug had shrank. A quick glance over at Bow and Glimmer revealed they had shrunk as well.

Weird.

She looked down at herself, sword in hand. Her clothes were different. Rather than her usual red and maroon outfit that she wore, she was wearing a white body suit with matching boots and a cape around her waist. Strategic cutouts were placed across her thighs and chest, just where she liked to cut them in her clothes. She had gold metals details all over her body, and she could feel a heavy weight on her forehead. She brushed at it with her hand, and realized she was wearing a metal tiara.

The weirdest part? She was glowing.

In front of her, the bug relaxed. It settled into the ground, as if it were waiting for her orders.

End Notes

anyways catra is big gay for adora. hmu on tumblr @clintonvevo

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